

Application Checklist & Fee Tracker

Application fees in Philly typically run \$20–\$75 and are **non-refundable**. Applying blind is how renters burn \$300 in a month with nothing to show for it. This checklist makes sure you only pay fees where you have a real shot.

Your Document Folder — Build It Once

Make a folder on your phone (Google Drive or iCloud) with these, so you can apply within minutes of seeing a unit:

- ☐ Photo ID (driver's license, state ID, or passport)
- ☐ Last 2–4 pay stubs OR income docs per the Income Documentation Guide
- ☐ Last 2–3 months of bank statements
- ☐ Your completed Renter Resume (PDF)
- ☐ Your Reference Sheet (PDF)
- ☐ Explanation letter(s), if your screening will show an issue
- ☐ Voucher paperwork, if applicable
- ☐ Cosigner's info and consent, if you're using one

Before You Pay Any Fee — Ask This

Fees are only worth paying when you'd actually pass screening. Send this BEFORE applying:

“Before I apply, can you tell me your screening criteria — minimum credit score, income requirement, and how you treat past evictions or collections? I want to make sure I qualify before paying the fee.”

This isn't just a polite request — it's your legal right. Philadelphia's Renters' Access Act requires landlords to give you their written screening criteria BEFORE accepting your application or fee. A landlord who refuses is breaking the law — and telling you something.

Scam Red Flags — Never Ignore These

- Asked for money before you've seen the unit (in person or live video tour) — **walk away**
- Payment by wire transfer, gift cards, Cash App, or crypto only
- Rent dramatically below every comparable listing in the neighborhood
- “Owner is out of the country” and will “mail you the keys”
- Pressure to sign or pay today because “others are waiting”
- They “don't need” an application or any ID from you — real landlords screen

Fee & Application Tracker

Property / Address	Date	Fee	Contact	Status	Follow up

Status codes: A = applied, V = viewed, W = waiting, D = denied, ✓ = approved. Follow up on every application after 3 business days — the squeaky wheel gets the lease.

Move-In Cost Worksheet

Cost	Amount	Saved?
First month's rent		
Security deposit		
Last month's rent (if required)		
Renters insurance (≈\$10–20/mo)		
Utility setup / transfers		
Moving (truck, helpers)		
TOTAL		

KNOW YOUR DEPOSIT RIGHTS (PA)

In Pennsylvania, a landlord generally cannot require more than two months' rent as a security deposit in the first year of a lease (one month after the first year). If move-in costs feel impossible, ask about deposit alternatives — some landlords accept low-cost deposit insurance instead of a full deposit. [MORGAN: add deposit-alternative recommendation/link]